

15 Ishmael

Abraham's firstborn son, not the child of promise, yet heard and blessed by God.

Ishmael was Abraham's first son, born to Hagar, Sarah's Egyptian servant. When God promised a son through Sarah, Abraham prayed, "O that Ishmael might live before thee!" God answered that the covenant would pass through Isaac, but Ishmael too would become a great nation. After Isaac was born, conflict drove Ishmael and his mother into the desert. There God heard the boy's cry and saved him. He grew up an archer, fathered twelve princes, and stood beside Isaac at their father's grave. His name means "God shall hear," and God heard him all his life.

At a glance

Name	Ishmael, "God shall hear" (KJV margin)
Family	Son of Abraham and Hagar; half-brother of Isaac
Work	An archer in the wilderness (Genesis 21:20)
Key places	The wilderness of Beersheba; the wilderness of Paran
Key people	Abraham, Hagar, Sarah, Isaac, Esau
Lifespan	137 years (Genesis 25:17)
Main passages	Genesis 16; 17:18–27; 21:8–21; 25:9–18
New Testament	Unnamed son of the bondwoman (Galatians 4)

"And as for Ishmael, I have heard thee: Behold, I have blessed him, and will make him fruitful, and will multiply him exceedingly; twelve princes shall he beget, and I will make him a great nation."

Genesis 17:20, KJV

The life of Ishmael

Ages are worked out from Genesis 16:16, 17:25 and 25:7-9. Traditional dates put his birth c. 2080 BC; many scholars place the patriarchs c. 2000-1700 BC.

Before birth	● Named by God The angel of the LORD tells Hagar she will bear a son and call him Ishmael, "because the LORD hath heard thy affliction." <i>Genesis 16:11-12</i>
Birth	● Born to Abram Hagar bears Abram a son when Abram is eighty-six, and Abram names him Ishmael. <i>Genesis 16:15-16</i>
Age 13	● Circumcised On the day God gives the covenant sign, Abraham circumcises Ishmael and all the males of his house. <i>Genesis 17:23-26</i>
At Isaac's weaning	● Sent away Sarah sees Ishmael mocking and demands that he and his mother leave. Abraham is deeply grieved but obeys God's word and sends them into the wilderness. <i>Genesis 21:8-14</i>
In the wilderness	● Heard by God The water runs out, and God hears "the voice of the lad." A well appears, and God promises to make him a great nation. He grows up an archer in Paran and marries an Egyptian. <i>Genesis 21:15-21</i>
Age 89	● Buries his father Ishmael and Isaac together bury Abraham in the cave of Machpelah. <i>Genesis 25:8-9</i>
Age 137	● Dies His twelve sons have become princes of tribes. He dies and is "gathered unto his people." <i>Genesis 25:12-18</i>

Key activities

The word for "mocking" in Genesis 21:9 comes from the same root as Isaac's name, which means "he laughs." Some read it as mild teasing, others as scorn. Paul describes it as persecution (Galatians 4:29).

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- 1 Received a name from God.** Before he was born, God named him for the way he had heard his mother's distress. *Genesis 16:11*
 - 2 Was prayed for.** Abraham pleaded that Ishmael might live before God, and God said, "I have heard thee." *Genesis 17:18-20*
 - 3 Received the covenant sign.** He was circumcised at thirteen on the same day as Abraham. *Genesis 17:23-26*
 - 4 Mocked his brother.** At Isaac's weaning feast he was seen mocking, and his home was lost. *Genesis 21:8-10*
 - 5 Cried in the desert.** Near death from thirst, he was heard by God, who saved him through his mother. *Genesis 21:15-19*
 - 6 Grew up with God's help.** "God was with the lad," and he became an archer in the wilderness. *Genesis 21:20-21*
 - 7 Honored his father.** He stood with Isaac to bury Abraham. *Genesis 25:9*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Ishmael.

Old Testament

Genesis 25:12–18; 1 Chronicles 1:28–31	His twelve sons listed
Genesis 28:9; 36:3	Esau marries Ishmael's daughter
Genesis 37:25–28	Ishmaelite traders carry Joseph to Egypt
Judges 8:24	Midianite raiders called Ishmaelites
Psalms 83:6	Ishmaelites among Israel's enemies

New Testament

Galatians 4:22–31	The son "born after the flesh" in Paul's allegory
Romans 9:6–9	"In Isaac shall thy seed be called"
Echo: Psalm 34:6	God hears the cry of the needy

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did God promise concerning Ishmael (Genesis 17:20; 21:13, 18)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think God chose Isaac for the covenant but still blessed Ishmael?
3. *Apply:* Ishmael grew up with a painful family story. How can God be at work in someone whose family life is broken?
4. *Apply:* Isaac and Ishmael stood together at their father's grave. Is there a family member you need to stand with again?